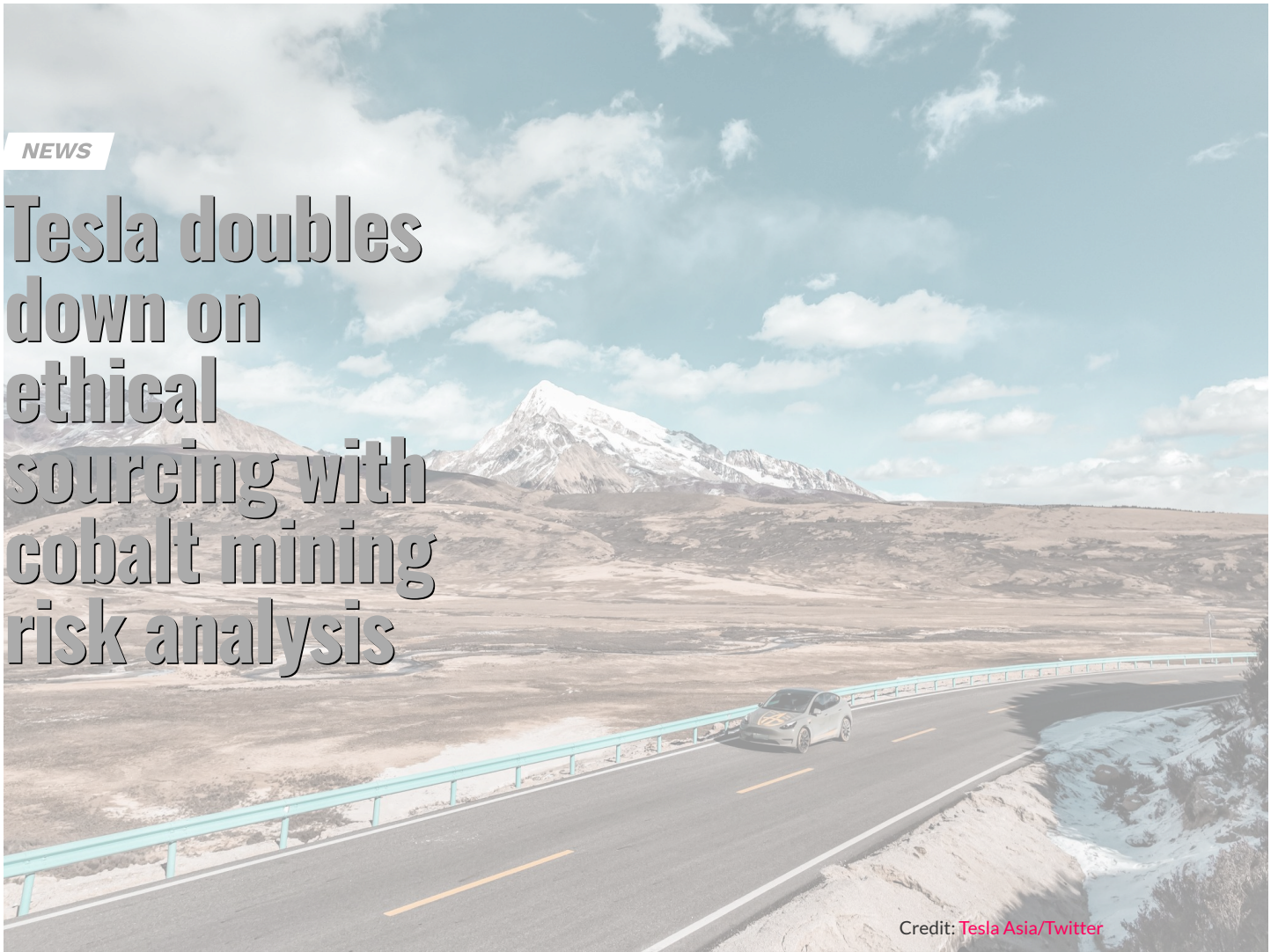




NEWS

Tesla doubles down on ethical sourcing with cobalt mining risk analysis

Credit: [Tesla Asia/Twitter](#)

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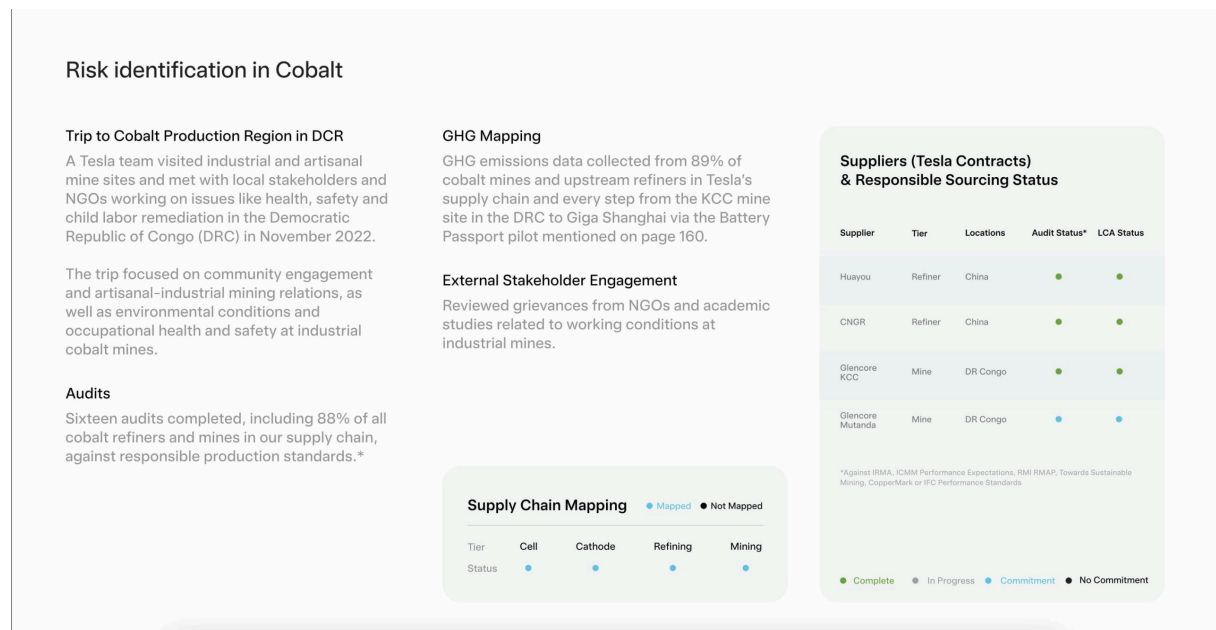
By [William Johnson](#) 

Tesla has published a new report on its efforts to make its cobalt supply chain significantly more ethical, safe, and secure.

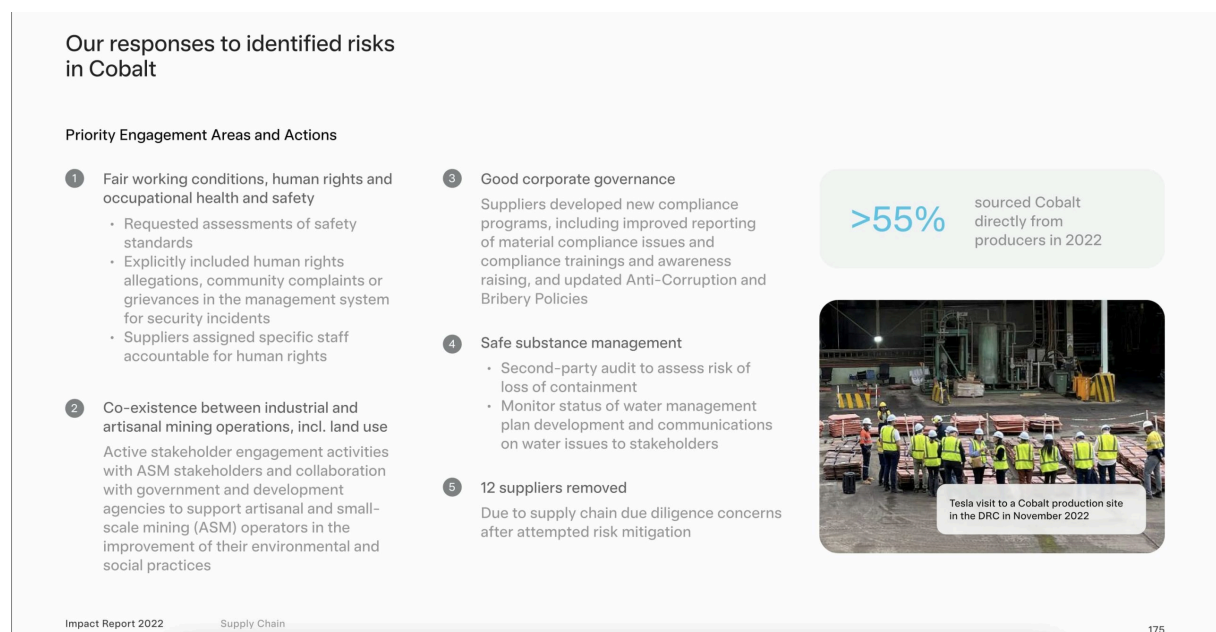
By far, cobalt is the most difficult to acquire mineral required to make a battery for an electric vehicle. The material often requires significant chemical processing to remove it from the ground; it is usually found in rock formations that can release toxic gases when mined, and to make things worse, the primary sources of the material are some of the poorest countries on Earth. Now, Tesla has published an analysis as [part of its 2022 Impact Report](#), detailing its efforts to make the mining process more ethical and safe.

According to Tesla's 2022 Impact Report, one of its primary sources of cobalt is, as defined by the United Nations, the poorest country on Earth, the Democratic Republic of the Congo. This country is found in Southern Central Africa, and despite its extraordinary material wealth, including a vast supply of cobalt, it is also the stage of countless human atrocities, civil wars, and human trafficking operations.

In efforts to make its cobalt mining more ethical, Tesla's report focused on a couple of critical factors. Foremost, the automaker has sent personnel to audit its suppliers, primarily in the DRC and China. At these supply locations, Tesla focused on environmental impact, impact on local communities, and general working conditions. Further, the American car maker worked with "local stakeholders and NGOs working on issues like health, safety, and child labor remediation" to help improve each of these risk factors.



Specifically, Tesla laid out five improvements that it was dedicated to implementing or has already implemented to improve its Cobalt supply chain, including "fair working conditions, human rights, and occupational health and safety," coexisting land use policies, "good corporate governance," "safe substance management," and removing unethical suppliers.



Besides these global improvements, Tesla also created a plan to improve its sourcing from the DRC, which has notoriously been the source of many ethical mining problems. Tesla notes that it is helping to dramatically improve the working conditions of "artisanal miners," or miners who are not part of a traditional corporation. The automaker achieves this through its founding membership of the Fair Cobalt Alliance, dedicated to improving cobalt mining practices globally.

Tesla supports efforts to improve conditions in the DRC

Tesla has a robust due diligence program in place to ensure we do not buy artisanal cobalt. We also understand that artisanal and small-scale mining (ASM) can sometimes be an important economic opportunity for members of local communities. Rather than disengaging, we support our suppliers and local stakeholders in addressing some of the challenges that affect their livelihoods.

Through our founding membership in the Fair Cobalt Alliance (FCA), we are focused on providing resources to adults that will improve their safety while at work and providing educational and employment opportunities to minors as an alternative to engaging in dangerous mining activities.



The FCA reported on its 2022 progress here.
Photo by the Fair Cobalt Alliance.

The FCA is a multi-stakeholder initiative that:



Supports formalization, living wages and dignified working conditions on cobalt (ASM) sites in the DRC



Provides protective equipment as well as organizes health and safety trainings



Supports schools, orphanages and medical centers to keep children out of mines



Luckily, Tesla isn't just dedicated to improving its sourcing regarding cobalt. The company outlined six different materials critical for battery manufacturing, which it has completed risk analyses of and has put forward similar standards of improvement. The six investigated materials include lithium, nickel, cobalt, aluminum, silica, and "3Tg"; tungsten, tin, tantalum, and gold.



5.3 Priority Materials

We support responsible mining and refining.



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Will is an auto enthusiast, a gear head, and an EV enthusiast above all. From racing, to industry data, to the most advanced EV tech on earth, he now covers it at Teslarati.